

Doc Id: MD-IT-002

Title: Incident Priority & Escalation Guidelines

Version: "1.0"

Effective Date: 2026-07-01

Owner Team: Service Desk

Applies To: All Meridian Dynamics IT support tickets and support teams

Review Cadence: Semiannual

MD-IT-002 - Incident Priority & Escalation Guidelines

1. Purpose

This guideline defines a consistent P1 P4 priority from business impact and urgency for every Meridian Dynamics IT ticket. It prevents priority from being set by capitalization, job title, or an unsupported statement that an issue is urgent. The guideline also names response targets, owning-team handoffs, and escalation thresholds. It applies after the ticket category is understood; the priority expresses when support must act, not which team possesses the relevant expertise. When evidence is incomplete, Service Desk records what is known, chooses the less severe supported priority, and immediately asks for the missing impact details.

2. Scope

The matrix applies to incidents and requests involving network access, accounts, hardware, software licensing, email and collaboration, security incidents, and general inquiries. It applies during business hours and after hours; response targets are elapsed time for P1 and P2 and business time for P3 and P4. Safety, confirmed compromise, or active data exposure may require emergency procedures beyond this IT matrix. Planned maintenance that follows an approved change is not an incident unless service exceeds its communicated window or unexpected impact occurs. Human-resources, legal, finance, and facilities matters are outside this taxonomy unless an IT service or security control is directly affected.

3. Definitions

Impact is the breadth and business consequence of the issue: one user, 2-9 users, 10 or more users, an entire location, or a critical service. Urgency is how quickly harm grows if support waits. critical means active severe harm, confirmed compromise, or no service for a critical operation. high means work is blocked or a confirmed near-term business event is at risk. medium means work is degraded but harm is contained or a workaround exists. low means a planned request, question, or issue with no current business interruption. Priority is the response order: P1 is highest and P4 is lowest. Initial response means a qualified analyst acknowledges, validates impact, and begins or coordinates action; it does not promise final resolution.

4. Policy / Procedure

Assign P1 when an outage affects 10 or more users and stops a critical business operation with no workaround; when a critical business service is unavailable;

or when active compromise, active data exposure, or dangerous hardware is confirmed. P1 requires immediate paging and continuous coordination.

Assign P2 when 2-9 users are blocked with no reasonable workaround; one user is blocked from a confirmed time-critical customer or operational event; or a security incident is suspected but active compromise is not yet confirmed. P2 requires an initial response within thirty minutes.

Assign P3 when one user is blocked without an immediate deadline, a limited group is degraded with a workable alternative, or a standard repair is needed. P3 requires an initial response within four business hours.

Assign P4 to planned access, hardware, software, and license requests; routine questions; cosmetic defects; and problems with an effective workaround and no near-term impact. P4 requires an initial response within one business day. Analysts record affected users, service, workaround, deadline, and evidence. Priority is reassessed whenever any of these facts changes.

5. Priority & escalation

Service Desk owns initial triage and the priority record. IT Infrastructure owns network, VPN, Wi-Fi, server, and DNS incidents. IT Security owns account-control, MFA, phishing, and security incidents. Workplace IT owns laptops, peripherals, printers, and meeting-room hardware. Business Applications owns email, collaboration, ERP, SaaS, and licensing. Service Desk remains the general_inquiry fallback when evidence does not support a specialist category.

P1 is paged immediately to the owning team and incident lead, with updates at least every thirty minutes. P2 is accepted by the owning team within thirty minutes and escalated to its lead if unacknowledged after fifteen minutes. P3 and P4 follow queue targets but escalate when impact increases or the response target is missed. A requester's executive title never changes priority by itself. Conflicting signals are resolved using observable impact, urgency, workaround, and security evidence, and the rationale is recorded.

6. Related documents

MD-IT-001 applies the matrix to MeridianConnect VPN. MD-IT-003 and MD-IT-004 apply it to account and MFA recovery. MD-IT-005 applies it to device and room hardware. MD-IT-006 and MD-IT-007 apply it to licensing and collaboration. MD-IT-008 defines security reporting and makes confirmed compromise a P1. MD-IT-009 and MD-IT-010 apply it to workforce transitions and remote work.

7. Revision history

Version 1.0 became effective on 2026-07-01. It establishes the 10-user P1 threshold, P2 time-critical single-user rule, response targets, closed team ownership, evidence requirements, and the rule that observable impact overrides unsupported urgency language or requester seniority.